



📅 19 Dec 2025

## 1) The smallest possible map is like this

```
A:: Cause
B:: Effect
A -> B
```

## 2) Comments (important)

- # starts a comment.
- Everything after # on that line is ignored.

This also means: **don't use # for hex colours** (`#ff0000`) because it will be treated as a comment.

## 3) Settings (styles at the top)

Settings look like **Key: Value** and usually go near the top.

Common settings:

- **Title:** text title shown above the diagram.
- **Background:** background colour (named colour or `rgb(r,g,b)`).
- **Default box colour:** default node fill colour.
- **Default box border:** default node border, like `1px solid gray`.
- **Default link colour:** default link/arrow colour.
- **Default link style:** `solid` | `dotted` | `dashed` | `bold`.
- **Default link width:** a number (interpreted like px), e.g. `2`.
- **Default box shape:** `rounded` for rounded nodes.
- **Default box shadow:** `none` | `subtle` | `medium` | `strong`.
- **Direction:** `top-bottom` | `bottom-top` | `left-right` | `right-left`.
- **Label wrap:** wraps node labels after N characters (best-effort).
- **Rank gap / Node gap:** spacing controls (small numbers like `2–8` are typical).

Colour rules (keep it simple):

- Use **named colours** like `red`, `aliceblue`, `seagreen`, `dimgray`, etc.
- Or use `rgb(r,g,b)`, e.g. `rgb(255, 0, 0)`.

Example style block:

```
Background: aliceblue
Default box colour: wheat
Default box shape: rounded
Default box border: 1px dotted dimgray
Default link colour: dimgray
Default link style: dotted
Default link width: 2
Default box shadow: subtle
Direction: left-right
```

## 4) Nodes

Define a node like this:

ID:: Label

- **ID** is a short name you use in links (like **A**, **B2**, **MyNode**).
- **Label** is what you see in the diagram (can include spaces).

Examples:

```
A:: A short label
B:: A longer label with spaces
```

## 5) Links (arrows)

Links look like this:

```
A -> B
```

You can create multiple links in one line using **|**:

```
A -> B | C
A | Q -> B
A | Q -> B | C
```

(That last one creates the full cross-product:  $A \rightarrow B$ ,  $A \rightarrow C$ ,  $Q \rightarrow B$ ,  $Q \rightarrow C$ .)

Optional link label + border:

```
A -> B [increases | 1px dotted gray]
```

Optional link label style + size (use **key=value** inside the brackets):

```
A -> B [label=increases | border=1px dotted gray | label style=italic | label size=10]
```

## 6) Grouping boxes (optional)

Grouping boxes are just lines starting with dashes:

- **--Label** opens a grouping box (level 1)
- **----Label** opens a nested grouping box (level 2)
- **----** closes the most recent level-2 grouping box
- **--** closes the most recent level-1 grouping box (and anything nested)

Example:

```
--Drivers
A:: Training quality
B:: Tool usability
--

--Outcomes
C:: Adoption
D:: Error rate
--

A | B -> C | D
```

## 7) Styling nodes inline (optional)

You can put a small “style list” after a node label:

```
A:: Hello [colour=red | border=2px dashed dimgray | shape=rounded]
```

Supported node attributes:

- **colour=...** (or **color=...**): fill colour
- **background=...**: fill colour (alias)
- **border=...**: border like **2px solid gray**
- **shape=rounded**: rounded corners

## 8) Border syntax (for nodes and links)

Border text is:

WIDTH STYLE COLOUR

Examples:

1px solid blue  
2px dotted gray